

Anatomy LESSONS

The first novel by a bestselling physician-writer is a sprawling love story

| By S. Prasannarajan |

It is unlikely that you will come across such a sentence even in a novel that unravels man's innermost mysteries: "If the beating heart is pure theatre, a playful, moody, extroverted organ cavorting in the chest, then the liver, sitting under the diaphragm, is a figurative painting, stolid and silent." Then Abraham Verghese, a professor of medicine at Stanford University, USA, who uses Tolstoy's *The Death of Ivan Ilych* as a textbook on end-of-life, is not just another storyteller; it is the intercellular drama of human anatomy that creates the frisson in his stories. And so far, those bestselling stories were not fiction. His first book, *My Own Country*, which has been made into a film by Mira Nair, is a personal narrative of his years caring for the HIV-infected in rural Tennessee. *The Tennis Partner*, his second, too, is a memoir that turns the game of friendship into a meditation on loss and relapse. *Cutting for Stone* is Verghese's first novel, a love story whose most poignant moments are played out in an operation theatre, an arena where the seared emotions of human intimacies are laid bare. Inhabited by exiles and refugees from their own worst secrets, spanning three continents and half-a-century, it is a saga in which the power of passion has the rawness of the Old Testament and the sweep of a vintage Russian classic. Verghese choreographs the volitions and violations, the temptations and transgressions, of the displaced and the orphaned to a terrifying but redemptive finale.

It begins with a voyage across the Indian Ocean, aboard the cargo ship *Calangute* sailing toward Aden in the year of India's independence. The ship carries, among its few passengers, Sister Mary Joseph Praise, a 19-year old novitiate from Cochin, who is on her way to take up her first nursing assignment in Africa, and Thomas Stone, a young English surgeon, who is leaving the Indian Medical Service for better opportunities elsewhere. Death and seasickness bring the nun

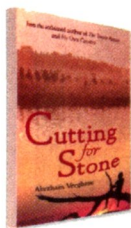
and the hawk-eyed doctor together for a while in the first flash of forbidden love. Later, at Missing Hospital in Addis Ababa, the nun, already violated by a godless Africa, and the surgeon, a genius with his nine fingers but almost Heathcliffian in his torment, turn their secret relationship into a romance sustained by death, birth and atonement. The bride of Christ dies in the operation theatre of Missing giving birth to conjoined twins, "obstetric miracles". The woman who brings them to this world and who will become their mother for the rest of their lives, Dr Hemalatha, names them Marion, after the patron saint of obstetrics and gynaecology, and Shiva, after the dancing god.

The novel, told in the grand strokes of a Victorian realist, mainly anatomises three relationships. Sister Mary and Stone, lovers deprived of the powers to express themselves, form the foundation on which Verghese, a portraitist of castaways, builds his story of separation and salvation. Then there are the infallible Hema, the best gynaecologist in Addis Ababa and the one who can overpower a rogue pilot by locking his spermatic cord with her surgeon's fingers, and Dr Ghosh, another physician of the hospital. Their love story

too doesn't have a happy ending, but there is fulfillment when they, the foster parents of the twins, become part of the transcontinental evolution of the Mary-Joseph story. Still, it is the twins, biologically separated by a wound that lingers in their shared memory, who restore the beauty of their parents' lost lives. The twins' life began in an operation theatre in Addis Ababa. In another in Bronx, they restore the beauty of their own oneness in an act that is more than a leap in surgical science. It is redemption. Like Scheherazade, Marion, the narrator, has to keep telling the story. It's about being alive. About living the lives of others as well.

The novel is mostly set in Emperor Haile Selassie's Ethiopia, which also happen to be the birthplace of Verghese, whose parents came from Kerala. It is not the Ethiopia immortalised by

"I see all writing, whatever form it takes, as being a function of that grand privilege of being a physician which in my case is everything."



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